

TO SIR, WITH LOVE:
Mahajan with sakhar
shala students in
Bhenda



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

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We wanted to give these children of migrant labourers across Maharashtra the freedom to choose a better life.

PRAVIN MAHAJAN, Founder, Janarth

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why the emphasis is not on reading and writing, but on oral learning and counting.

Like all ambitious projects, it has not been easy to get sakhar shalas off the ground. The biggest challenge that

Janarth had to overcome was convincing the Government about the actual number of migrant children. “Nobody believed us when we quoted the number of migrant families and their affected children,” says Mahajan. For any sort of remedial action by the Government or local bodies, they have to believe that this invisible population has problems that need to be addressed. To that effect, Janarth has succeeded in focusing attention on the invisible underclass.

Having expanded the capacity to 15,000 children, Janarth is now feeling stretched as no other agency has come forward to offer help. With many more Gopals wandering aimlessly out of school, it's time this happened. ■